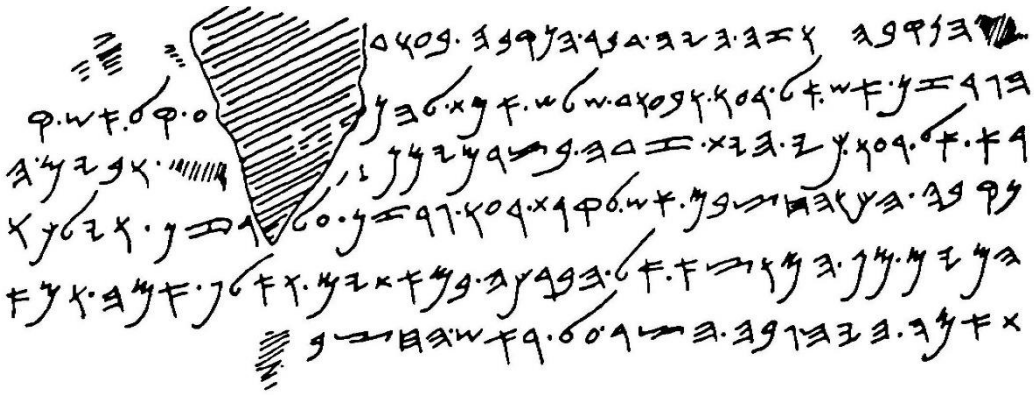
Historical Grammar of Hebrew

Benjamin D. Suchard, Leiden University, 2023



Kwadraat-schrift	Paleo-Hebreeuws schrift	Cursief	Naam	Trans-literatie	Getals-waarde
א	𐤀	𐡀	*ʾălēp̄*	ʾ	1
ב	𐤁	𐡁	*beṯ*	*b, b̲*	2
ג	𐤂	𐡂	*gimɛl*	*g, ḡ*	3
ד	𐤃	𐡃	*dăleṯ*	*d, d̲*	4
ה	𐤄	𐡄	*he*	*h*	5
ו	𐤅	𐡅	*wâw*	*w*	6
ז	𐤆	𐡆	*záyin*	*z*	7
ח	𐤇	𐡇	*ḥeṯ*	*ḥ*	8
ט	𐤈	𐡈	*ṭeṯ*	*ṭ*	9
י	𐤉	𐡉	*yod̲*	*y*	10
כ, ך	𐤊	𐡊, 𐡒	*kap̄*	*k, k̲*	20
ל	𐤋	𐡋	*lămɛd̲*	*l*	30
מ, ם	𐤌	𐡌, 𐡍	*mem*	*m*	40
נ, ן	𐤍	𐡎, 𐡏	*nun*	*n*	50
ס	𐤎	𐡐	*sămɛḵ*	*s*	60
ע	𐤏	𐡑	*ʿáyin*	*ʿ*	70
פ, ף	𐤐	𐡓, 𐡔	*pe*	*p, p̄*	80
צ, ץ	𐤑	𐡕, 𐡖	*ṣăd̲e*	*ṣ*	90
ק	𐤒	𐡗	*qop̄*	*q*	100
ר	𐤓	𐡘	*reš*	*r*	200
שׂ	} 𐤔	𐡙	*śin*	*ś* }	300
שׁ		𐡚	*šin*	*š*	
ת	𐤕	𐡛	*tâw*	*t, ṯ*	400

J.P. Lettinga (Leiden, 2012), *Grammatica van het Bijbels Hebreeuws*, twelfth, revised edition by M. F. J. Baasten & W. Th. van Peursen

1. Proto-Northwest-Semitic

1.1 Classification

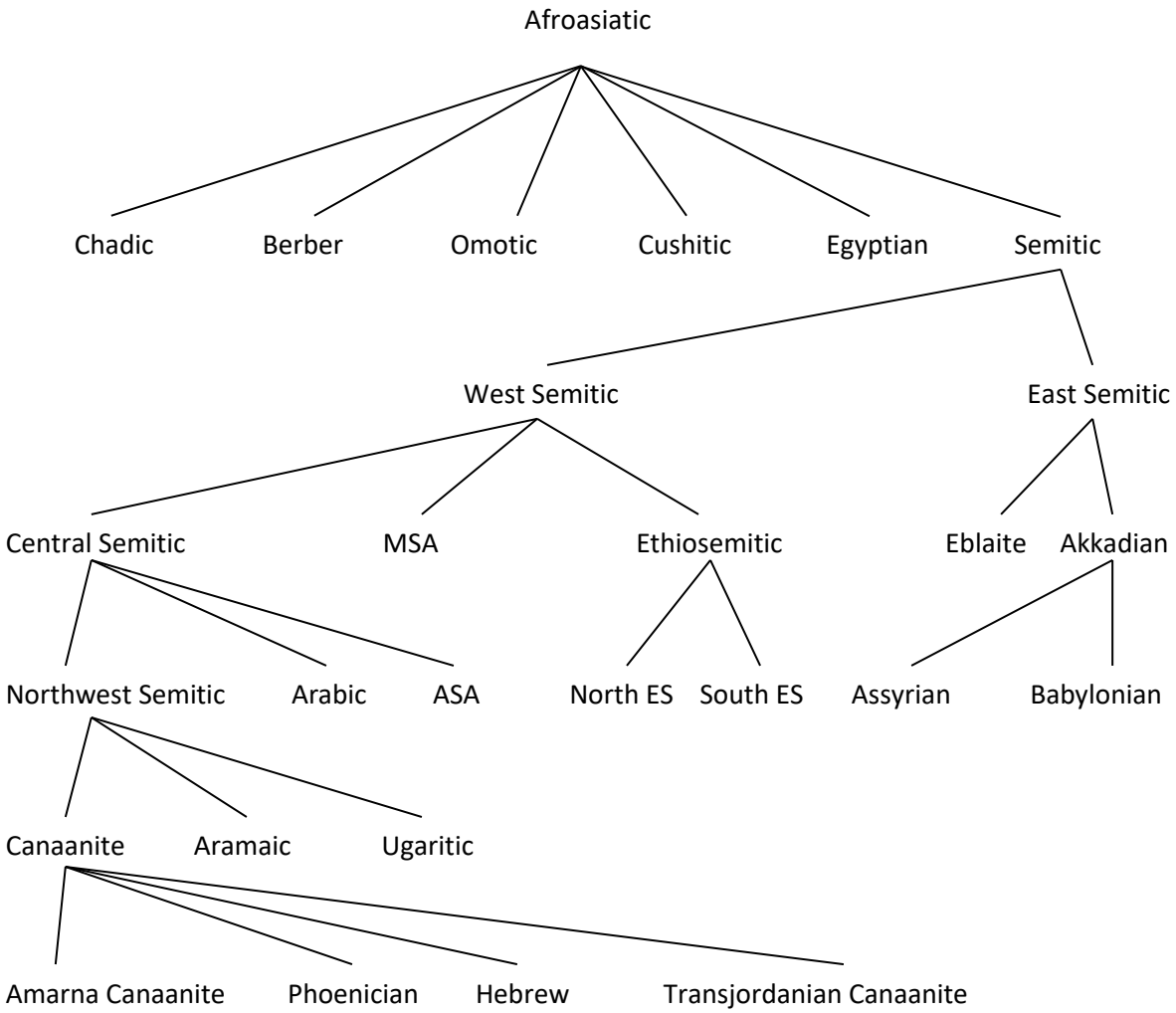


Figure 1.1 The genetic classification of the Semitic languages

Abbreviations and most important languages:

MSA: Modern South Arabian, includes Mehri

ASA: Ancient South Arabian, includes Sabaic

North ES: North Ethiosemitic, includes Gəʿəz (Classical Ethiopic) and Tigriña

South ES: South Ethiosemitic, includes Amharic

Transjordanian Canaanite includes Ammonite, Moabite, and Edomite

1.2 Phonology

1.2.1 Consonants

Proto-Northwest-Semitic is reconstructed with the same 29 consonantal phonemes as Proto-Semitic, shown in table 1.1. The IPA value of consonants is indicated where this differs from the transcription used. All consonants may be geminated (i.e. realized as long).

Table 1.1 The consonantal phonemes of Proto-Northwest-Semitic

	bilabial	interdental	alveolar	palatal	velar	pharyngeal	glottal
plosives							
voiceless	*p		*t		*k		*ʾ [ʔ]
voiced	*b		*d		*g		
ejective			*ṭ [t’]		*q [k’]		
affricates							
voiceless			*^{t}s [t͡s]				
voiced			*^{d}z [d͡z]				
ejective			*^{t}ṣ [t͡s’]				
fricatives							
voiceless		*θ	*s		*ḫ [x]	*ḥ [ħ]	*h
voiced		*ð			*ġ [ɣ]	*ʿ [ʕ]	
ejective		*θ̣ [t͡θ’]					
laterals							
voiceless			*ś [ɬ]				
voiced			*l				
ejective			*ṣ́ [t͡ɬ’]				
nasals							
voiced	*m		*n				
resonants							
voiced	*w		*r	*y [j]			

1.2.2 Vowels

Like Proto-Semitic, Proto-Northwest-Semitic had three contrastive vowel qualities and a length distinction, resulting in six vocalic phonemes: *a, *ā, *i, *ī, *u, and *ū. While *aw, *ay, *iw, *iy, *uw, and *uy are often referred to as diphthongs (as in this syllabus), they do not seem to have had a different status as such, rather being a normal sequence of a short vowel and a glide.

1.2.3 Phonotactics

Reconstructible syllable structures are CV̆, e.g. *ya; CV̄, e.g. *ðū; and CV̆C, e.g. *tim. Word-initially, syllables could start with two consonants, as in *bnum 'son (nom.)'.

The stress system of Proto-Northwest-Semitic cannot be reconstructed, as its daughters reflect either a system that regularly stressed every penultimate syllable (Canaanite, Aramaic) or a weight-sensitive system, where heavy syllables attract the stress (Ugaritic).

1.3 Morphology

1.3.1 Pronouns

Personal pronouns As in Biblical Hebrew, Proto-Northwest-Semitic personal pronouns occur in three persons, two genders (masculine and feminine), and (unlike Biblical Hebrew) three numbers (singular, plural, and dual). Personal pronouns can be either independent, i.e. used as words in their own right, or suffixed to nouns, verbs, or particles. Table 1.2 presents a reconstruction of the Proto-Northwest-Semitic independent personal pronouns. According to the Semiticist convention, the third person is presented first. As the dual pronouns have been lost in most languages, they are hard to reconstruct and left out of the table. There is no difference in meaning between *ʾana(h) and *ʾanāku.

In the third person only, separate oblique (non-nominative) forms of the independent pronouns can be reconstructed for Proto-Northwest-Semitic, which are formed with an additional suffix *-(V)tV; these are not preserved in Hebrew.

Independent personal pronouns are mainly (though not exclusively, and not obligatorily) used to express the subject of a sentence. For other syntactic roles, pronominal suffixes are used. On nouns, these suffixes indicate possession; on verbs, they indicate the direct or indirect object; and they may also combine with prepositions and other particles. In Proto-Northwest-Semitic, the nominal and verbal suffixes are identical in all persons but the first person singular. A reconstruction of the pronominal suffixes is given in table 1.3. The distribution of the first person singular suffixes *-ī and *-ya is uncertain.

Table 1.2 The PNWS independent pronouns

person	singular	plural
3m.	*hūʾa	*hum
3f.	*hīʾa	*hin
2m.	*ʾanta(h)	*ʾantum
2f.	*ʾanti	*ʾantin
1	*ʾana(h), *ʾanāku	*naḥnu or *naḥnā

Table 1.3 The PNWS suffixed pronouns

person	singular	plural
3m.	*-hu	*-hum
3f.	*-hā	*-hin
2m.	*-ka	*-kum
2f.	*-ki	*-kin
1	*-ī, *-ya (on nouns), *-nī (on verbs)	*-nā

Other pronouns Some singular demonstrative pronouns of near deixis can securely be reconstructed for Proto-Northwest-Semitic: masculine *ðū (nom.), *ðī (gen.), and *ðā (acc.), and feminine *ðāt-. The reconstruction of the plural is uncertain; probably, it should be something like *ʾVll-. The demonstratives behave like adjectives (see below) and are occasionally used as relative pronouns. For far deixis, the third person independent personal pronouns are used.

The interrogative pronouns do not distinguish gender or number, but there is an animacy distinction between *mīya 'who' and *mah 'what'. A Proto-Northwest-Semitic interrogative adjective *ʾayy- 'which' is also reconstructible, but does not survive as an independent word in Biblical Hebrew.

1.3.2 Nouns and adjectives

As in Biblical Hebrew, Proto-Northwest-Semitic nouns and adjectives consist of a consonantal root and a pattern. They are inflected for gender, number, case, and state.

Gender Nouns and adjectives are either masculine or feminine; masculine is the unmarked gender. Feminine nouns may be morphologically unmarked or marked by one of the two feminine suffixes, *-t- and *-at-. Adjectives agree with their head nouns in gender; feminine adjectives are always marked by a feminine suffix.

Number Proto-Northwest-Semitic nouns and adjectives may occur in the singular, the dual, or the plural. The number is marked by an ending, which also indicates the word's case; these nominal endings will be discussed below. In many feminine and some masculine nouns, as well as all feminine adjectives, a plural suffix *-āt- occurs between the stem and the ending; if the singular contains either of the feminine suffixes, *-t- or *-at-, this is replaced by *-āt-. The masculine endings can also occur on feminine nouns, which are still treated as feminine as far as agreement is concerned.

While the plural is predominantly marked by the addition of the plural ending, some words also change their stem in the plural (but not in the dual). Most importantly, the Proto-Northwest-Semitic nouns of the very frequent *qaṭl-, *qiṭl-, and *quṭl-

patterns (the so-called segolates) insert an *a between the second and third radical in the plural stem. The same process takes place in the feminine counterparts of these nouns, of the *qaṭl-at-, *qiṭl-at-, and *quṭl-at- patterns. Some other nouns also have a different stem in the plural; notable examples are *bn- 'son', plural *ban- 'sons', and *yawm- 'day', plural *yam- 'days'. Finally, a few words have a completely different stem in the plural, like *nas- 'women', associated with the singular *ʾinθ-at- 'woman'.

Case In Proto-Northwest-Semitic, nouns and adjectives could occur in one of three cases: the nominative, used for the subject and the nominal predicate; the genitive, used in construct chains (see *State* below) and after prepositions; and the accusative, used for verbal objects and adverbial phrases. Case was marked by endings following the stem (and the feminine suffix, when present). In the singular, the nominative was marked by *-u-, the genitive by *-i-, and the accusative by *-a-.[1] The dual and the plural only made a distinction between nominative and oblique (genitive/accusative), the endings being *-ā- (nominative) and *-ay- (oblique) in the dual, *-ū- (nominative) and *-ī (oblique) in the masculine plural, and *-u- and *-i- in the feminine plural.

State As in Biblical Hebrew, Proto-Northwest-Semitic nouns and adjectives could occur in two states, the absolute and the construct. The construct state, indicating possession by the following noun (which then takes the genitive case), simply consisted of the stem (including feminine suffix) and case ending. The absolute state was marked by a separate morpheme: *-m in the singular and feminine plural and *-na (or *-ni) in the dual and masculine plural, attached to the case ending; these morphemes are known as *mimation* and *nunation*, respectively, from the names for the Arabic letters *m* and *n*.

The different nominal endings in Proto-Northwest-Semitic, as well as the *-a-insertion in the plural of *qVtl- nouns, are illustrated by *kalbum 'dog' and *kalbatum 'bitch' in table 1.4.

1.3.3 Verbs

Tense, aspect, mood The Proto-Northwest-Semitic verb distinguished several tenses or aspects and moods. In this section, they will be cited in the third person masculine singular, except for the imperative (which only occurs in the second person).

[1] The so-called diptotic inflection, which should be reconstructed for PNWS based on its occurrence in Ugaritic and Classical Arabic, had separate endings for the absolute state: nom. *-u, gen. *-a, acc. *-a, without mimation. This inflection has not left any traces in Hebrew.

Table 1.4 Proto-Northwest-Semitic nominal declension

number/case	'dog(s)' (m.)	'bitch(es)' (f.)
singular		
nominative	*kalb-u(-m)	*kalb-at-u(-m)
genitive	*kalb-i(-m)	*kalb-at-i(-m)
accusative	*kalb-a(-m)	*kalb-at-a(-m)
dual		
nominative	*kalb-ā(-na)	*kalb-at-ā(-na)
genitive/accusative	*kalb-ay(-na)	*kalb-at-ay(-na)
plural		
nominative	*kalab-ū(-na)	*kalab-āt-u(-m)
genitive/accusative	*kalab-ī(-na)	*kalab-āt-i(-m)

The *prefix conjugation* is a collection of three or four separate tenses that form the core of the inherited Semitic verbal system. All three use the same prefixes (and some suffixes) which mark them for person, gender and number.

The *preterite*, *jussive,* or *short imperfect* consisted of a bare verbal stem with personal affixes. It was used to express past events (with perfective aspect), wishes, and third person commands. Example: *ya-qṭul 'he killed'[2] or 'may he kill', 'let him kill'. In the fientive G-stem (see below), the stem of the prefix conjugations was shaped like *-qṭul- or *-qṭil-, while the stative G-stem prefix conjugation stem was shaped like *-qṭal-.

The *(long) imperfect* consisted of the same stem with the same prefixes, as well as a suffix *-u, if no other suffixes were present. If other vocalic suffixes *were* present, an additional *-na was added that is absent in the preterite and the subjunctive (discussed below). The long imperfect was used to express nonpast events or past events that occurred iteratively or habitually (i.e. with imperfective aspect), e.g. *ya-qṭul-u 'he kills', 'he is killing', 'he will kill', 'he would always kill', 'he kept killing', etc.; note the plural *ya-qṭul-ū-na, with the added *-na as compared to the preterite and subjunctive plural, *ya-qṭul-ū.

The *subjunctive* was similar to the preterite, but was marked by *-a if no other suffixes followed. It is used to indicate wishes or the intended result of another action, e.g. *ya-qṭul-a 'may he kill', 'let him kill' or 'in order to kill', 'so that he kill'. The difference with the volitive use of the jussive is not very clear.

The *energic* has left few traces in attested languages; based on forms in Arabic and Ugaritic, it is reconstructed as a form of the prefix conjugation with an *-n-suffix of

[2] As the dummy root qṭl means 'to kill' in Aramaic, we may translate it as such to illustrate the meaning of the various verbal forms.

controversial vocalization. It may originally have expressed some modal nuance, or perhaps a future tense.

The *suffix conjugation* or *perfect* consisted of a different stem than the prefix conjugation and exclusively marked its subject through suffixes. When used with stative verbs (see below), it expressed a state, which was unmarked for tense, e.g. *kabid-a 'he is/was/will be heavy'. When used with fientive verbs, it indicated a past event, probably with perfect/anterior aspect, e.g. *qaṭal-a 'he has killed', 'he had killed'. In both cases, then, the perfect expressed a state, which might or might not have resulted from an earlier event.

The *imperative* was used to express commands. It took the shape of the second person jussive without the prefix, e.g. *qṭul 'kill (m.sg.)' (cf. the jussive *ta-qṭul 'you (m.sg.) killed', 'may you kill'). For this reason, the imperative will be referred to as one of the prefix conjugations, where relevant, even though no prefixes are present. Opponents of the reconstruction of word-initial consonant clusters in Proto-Northwest-Semitic prefer to reconstruct the imperative with a short vowel between the first two radicals, e.g. *quṭul, *kabad or *kibad.

Reflexes of multiple *infinitive* formations are attested. The most common ones (for the G-stem, see below) were probably *qaṭāl-, *qiṭl-, and *qiṭlat-, all meaning 'to kill'.

Finally, there were *active* and *passive participles*. The active G-stem participle (see below) was formed like *qāṭil- 'killing (m.sg.)'. Attested passive G-stem participles reflect *qaṭīl- and *qaṭūl-, both 'killed (m.sg.)'; both forms were probably present in Proto-Northwest-Semitic. The participles were unmarked for tense and aspect and largely behaved like regular adjectives.

Person, gender, number Like the personal pronoun, the verb distinguishes three persons, two genders (masculine and feminine) and three numbers (singular, dual, plural). The first person does not distinguish gender. Verbs agree with their subject.

An overview of the different forms of the G-stem strong verb is given in table 1.5. The dual forms, only attested in Ugaritic and fairly uncertain, have been left out. Note that the prefix consonants and suffixes are the same for the other verbal stems (see below); only the stem and prefix vowels vary.

Verbal stems As in other Semitic languages, different verbal stems can be derived from the same verbal root. In comparative Semitics, each stem is known by a label which reflects one of its formal or semantic features; the primary stems reflected in Hebrew are the G-stem (German *Grundstamm*), the N-stem (formed with an n-prefix), the D-stem (German *Dopplungsstamm*) and the C-stem (causative).

The G-stem (Hebrew *qal*) is the basic, underived stem. It is the most frequent and is semantically unmarked. A distinction is made between fientive roots, expressing

Table 1.5 Paradigm of the strong PNWS verb (fientive G-stem)

person	prefix conjugations	suffix conjugation
3m.sg.	*ya-qṭul(-u/-a)	*qaṭal-a
3f.sg.	*ta-qṭul(-u/-a)	*qaṭal-at
2m.sg.	*ta-qṭul(-u/-a)	*qaṭal-ta
2f.sg.	*ta-qṭul-ī(-na)	*qaṭal-ti
1sg.	*ʾa-qṭul(-u/-a)	*qaṭal-tu
3m.pl.	*ya-qṭul-ū(-na)	*qaṭal-ū
3f.pl.	*ta-qṭul-na	*qaṭal-ā
2m.pl.	*ta-qṭul-ū(-na)	*qaṭal-tum
2f.pl.	*ta-qṭul-na	*qaṭal-tin
1pl.	*na-qṭul(-u/-a)	*qaṭal-nā

events, and stative roots, expressing states.[3] The forms of the fientive G-stem were discussed in the previous section. In Proto-Northwest-Semitic, the prefix vowel of the prefix conjugations was *-a- and the stem was *-qṭul- or *-qṭil-,[4] as in *ya-qṭul-u 'he will kill', while the stem of the suffix conjugation had two *a vowels, as in *qaṭal-a 'he has killed'. In the prefix conjugation of stative roots, the vowel of the prefixes was *-i- and the stem contained an *a vowel, as in *yi-kbad-u 'he will become heavy', while the second vowel of the suffix conjugation was either *-i-, as in *kabid-a 'he is/was/will be heavy', or *-u-, as in *ʿamuq-a 'it is/was/will be deep'. Whether the G-stem stative suffix conjugation has *i or *u in the stem is lexically determined. The occurrence of *-a-prefixes with fientive stems and *-i-prefixes with stative stems is known as the Barth–Ginsberg Law. An additional difference between fientive and stative roots is found in the participle: whereas fientive G-stems form both the active participle *qāṭil- 'killing (m.sg.)' and the passive participles *qaṭīl- and *qaṭūl- 'killed (m.sg.)', stative roots form what we may call a stative participle on the same base as the suffix conjugation, e.g. *kabid- 'heavy (m.sg.)', *ʿamuq- 'deep (m.sg.)'.

The N-stem (Hebrew *nipʿal*) is formally marked by a prefixed *n(a)-. Semantically, it is mediopassive, expressing a range of meanings where the subject is the patient of the verb, e.g. passive, medial, and reciprocal; additionally, it forms ingressives of stative roots. The stem of the suffix conjugation is *naqṭal-, while the stem of the prefix conjugations is *-nqaṭil-; as is the case with stative G-stem verbs, the prefix vowel is *-i-, resulting in forms like *yi-nqaṭil-u 'he will be killed'.

[3] Or, more accurately, expressing a high degree of affectedness of the subject.
[4] Also *-qtal- if the second or third radical was a guttural (pharyngeal or glottal consonant or velar fricative).

The D-stem (Hebrew *piʿel*) is marked by gemination of the second radical in all forms. It expresses a range of different meanings, mainly transitive. The stem of the suffix conjugation is *qaṭṭil-, and the same stem is used for the prefix conjugations. It is unclear whether the Proto-Northwest-Semitic prefix vowel should be reconstructed as *-u-, the form inherited from Proto-Semitic (i.e. *yu-qaṭṭil-u), or as *-a-, which is somewhat supported by evidence from Ugaritic and Hebrew (i.e. *ya-qaṭṭil-u). As in all other derived stems but (possibly) the N-stem, the participle is formed with the prefix *mu- and the stem of the prefix conjugations, yielding *mu-qaṭṭil-.

The C-stem (Hebrew *hip̄ʿil*; alternatively Š-stem or H-stem, based on the prefixes) most commonly expresses a causative meaning. The most probable reconstructions are *haqṭil- (from older *saqṭil-) for the stem of the suffix conjugation and *-saqṭil- for the stem of the prefix conjugations. The prefix vowel is the same as that of the D-stem, and similarly, the participle is to be reconstructed as *mu-saqṭil-.

All of these stems, except for the N-stem, could give rise to further derivation. The so-called internal passive stems (sometimes called Gp, Dp, and Cp; Hebrew passive *qal*, *puʿal*, and *hɔp̄ʿal*) are not marked by affixes, but express their passivity through a different vowel pattern. The Gp prefix conjugation can be reconstructed as *yu-qṭal-u 'he will be killed'; other forms are uncertain. Additionally, reflexive or reciprocal meanings can be expressed by the *t-stems*, formed with a *t which was either infixed after the first radical (Gt, Ct) or prefixed before it (tD). Again, the precise reconstructions are uncertain.

The principal parts of the Proto-Northwest-Semitic paradigms of the derived stems are given in table 1.6.

Table 1.6 Proto-Northwest-Semitic verbal stems

tense	G fientive	G stative	D	C
suffix conjugation	*qaṭal-	*kabid-, *ʿamuq-	*qaṭṭil-	*haqṭil-
prefix conjugation	*ya-qṭul-, *ya-qṭil-	*yi-kbad-	*yV-qaṭṭil-	*yV-saqṭil-
participle	*qāṭil-	*kabid-, *ʿamuq-	*mu-qaṭṭil-	*mu-saqṭil-
	Gp	N	Dp	Cp
suffix conjugation	*quṭVl-	*naqṭal-	*quṭṭVl-	*huqṭVl-
prefix conjugation	*yu-qṭal-	*yi-nqaṭil-	*yu-qVṭṭal-	*yu-sVqṭal-
participle	*qaṭīl-, *qaṭūl-	*naqṭal- or *mu-nqaṭil-	*mu-qVṭṭal-	*mu-sVqṭal-
	Gt		tD	Ct
suffix conjugation	*qtaṭVl-?		*taqaṭṭVl-	*staqṭVl-?
prefix conjugation	*yi-qtaṭVl-		*yV-tqaṭṭVl-	*yV-staqṭVl-
participle	*mu-qtaṭVl-		*mu-tqaṭṭVl-	*mu-staqṭVl-

2. Proto-Canaanite

2.1 Phonological developments

2.1.1 Consonants

Some mergers and phonetic changes affect the Proto-Canaanite consonants. As these do not interact with the vocalic changes, they are hard to date; based on Egyptian transcriptions of Canaanite, they are probably *not* Proto-Canaanite developments per se, but later, areal changes, affecting the Iron Age Canaanite languages.[5]

(2.1) The interdentals *θ *ð *ẖ shift to alveolars, *s *z *^{t}ṣ; the emphatic lateral *ṡ also shifted to *^{t}ṣ, but maybe not yet at this point in time.

(2.2) *s, both original and from *θ, shifts to *š.

(2.3) The affricates *^{t}s and *^{d}z (but not *^{t}ṣ) become fricatives, *s and *z.[6]

Thus, Proto-Northwest-Semitic *θ and *s become *š, *ð and *^{d}z become *z, *ẖ merges with *ṣ (= *^{t}ṣ), and original *^{t}s becomes *s. This results in an inventory of 25 or 26 consonants: the 22 consonants represented by the Hebrew alphabet, plus *ḫ, *ġ, the lateral fricative *ś, and maybe *ṡ.

2.1.2 Lowering of short vowels

The two high, short vowels of Proto-Semitic are normally reconstructed as *i and *u, and the same reconstruction was given above. At some point in the prehistory of both Hebrew and Phoenician, however, they were lowered to *e and *o, respectively. While this may have predated Proto-Canaanite, this cannot be proven; but the development of the so-called triphthongs (see below) shows that it had already taken place by this time.

(2.4) *i and *u undergo a phonetic shift to *e and *o, respectively. Word-finally, *u (or *o) seems to have yielded *e.

Thus, *yaqṭulu > *yaqṭole and *yikbadu > *yekbade.

[5] But not all in the same way, cf. the *šibbóleṯ* incident of Judges 12:6.
[6] For the sake of consistency, *^{t}ṣ will be written as *ṣ from now on, even though it was still realized as an affricate.

2.1.3 Penultimate stress

Most stress-conditioned sound changes that take place in Canaanite, including the earliest ones, reflect a stress system where the second-to-last or penultimate syllable of every prosodic word was accented. Formulated as a rule:

(2.5) The stress falls on the penultimate syllable of every prosodic word.

E.g. the 3m.sg. perfect *qaṭála, imperfect *yaqṭóle, jussive *yáqṭol.

2.1.4 The Canaanite Shift

The so-called Canaanite Shift consists of a phonetic shift of all *ā (stressed and unstressed) to *ō, except when preceded by *w or *o. Syllable-final *ʾ had been lost, lengthening the preceding vowel; *ā resulting from this change also shifts to *ō. In a few words, the Canaanite Shift could operate because an original *o had dissimilated to *e due to an adjacent bilabial consonant. In non-initial unstressed syllables, *ō was raised further to *ū; in many cases, *ō was analogically restored.

(2.6) *Vʾ$ > *V̄$

(2.7) Unstressed *o > *e when adjacent to a bilabial consonant.

(2.8) *ā > *ō, except in syllables after *w and *o.

(2.9) Unstressed *ō > *ū in non-initial syllables.

E.g. *šalā́m- > *šalṓm- ‘wellbeing’; *raʾš- > *rāš- > *rōš- ‘head’; *qaṭálā > *qaṭálō > *qaṭálū ‘they (f.pl.) have killed’.

2.1.5 Triphthong contraction

So-called triphthongs, sequences of a short vowel, glide, and another vowel,[7] were contracted into a single, long vowel, with the quality of the second original vowel. In closed syllables, the resulting long vowel was shortened, as were other long vowels in closed syllables.[8]

(2.10) *V̆₁wV₂ and *V̆₁yV₂ > *V̄₂

(2.11) *V̄C$ > *V̆C$

[7] Not strictly triphthongs in the phonological sense of the word.
[8] Except those closed by a geminate consonant, as in *bāttíma ‘houses (obl.)’.

E.g. *mawét- > *mḗt- ‘dead (m.sg.)’; *qawámta > *qā́mta > *qámta ‘you (m.sg.) have stood up’.

2.2 Morphosyntactic developments

2.2.1 Pronouns

In the first person singular, contamination with the suffixed pronouns led to the creation of new independent pronouns, *ʾánī and *ʾanṓkī. In an ancestor of Biblical Hebrew, these forms came to replace original *ʾána and *ʾanṓke.

2.2.2 Nouns and adjectives

In earlier stages of Phoenician and Hebrew (but not of e.g. Moabite), the nunation found in the absolute state of the dual and plural was replaced by mimation due to contamination with the singular, resulting in forms like *kalbṓma/*kalbáyma ‘two dogs (nom./obl.)’, *kalabūma/*kalabīma ‘dogs (nom./obl.)’.

2.2.3 Verbs

Due to the Canaanite Shift (2.8), the perfect endings of the 3f.pl. and 1pl. shifted from *-ā and *-nā to *-ū and *-nū, respectively. This merged the 3f.pl. form with that of the 3m.pl. Similar to the change in the independent pronouns, the 1sg. perfect ending *-tu was replaced by *-tī.

After the Canaanite Shift, the word-final *t in the 3f.sg. perfect ending *-at was lost with compensatory lengthening, resulting in *-ā.

Probably due to a minor sound change, the *a in the first syllable of the D- and C-stems were replaced by *e in the perfect (but not elsewhere): D-stem *qeṭṭel- and C-stem *heqṭel-. In the C-stem prefix conjugations and participle, original *-saqṭel- had been analogically replaced by *-haqṭel-; the *h was subsequently lost, resulting in forms like *yaqṭel-.

The ‘infinitive construct’ of strong and some weak verbs, consisting of just the stem of the prefix conjugation with nominal inflection (e.g. G-stem *qṭul-um, D-stem *qaṭṭil-um, etc.) is not attested outside of Canaanite and may be a Proto-Canaanite innovation.

3. Proto-Hebrew

3.1 Phonological developments

3.1.1 n-assimilation

(3.1) *n before another consonant assimilates to that consonant.

3.1.2 First apocope

At some point after the contraction of triphthongs (section 2.1.5 above), all unstressed word-final short vowels were lost. As this caused many originally penultimate syllables to be in word-final position, the position of the accent was no longer predictable.

(3.2) Unstressed, word-final *a and *e are deleted.

E.g. *qaṭála > *qaṭál; *gabóha > *gabóh ‘it (m.) was high’; *yaqṭóle > *yaqṭól. Note the difference in stress between the imperfect *yaqṭól and the jussive *yáqṭol. This change also resulted in the presence of long vowels in closed syllables, as in *kalabíma > *kalabím ‘dogs (obl.)’.

3.1.3 Tonic lengthening

The case vowels of nouns and adjectives in the absolute state had not been affected by the first apocope (3.2), as they were not word-final: the mimation morpheme, *-m, followed, as in *kalbem ‘dog (nom./gen.)’. At some point after the first apocope, however, mimation was lost in the singular, probably due to a sound change like:

(3.3) Word-final *m is lost after unstressed vowels.

E.g. *dabárem > *dabáre ‘word (nom.gen.)’.

The next change, tonic lengthening, may have preceded or followed the loss of mimation, but evidence from Biblical Hebrew orthography make it more likely that the loss of mimation came first.

(3.4) Stressed, short vowels in open syllables become long, except when followed by a long vowel.

E.g. *dabáre > *dabā́re ‘word (nom./gen.)’; *kabéde > *kabḗde ‘heavy (m.sg. nom./gen.)’; *gabóhe > *gabṓhe ‘high (m.sg. nom.gen.)’; *ʾakalátam > *ʾakalā́tam ‘she ate them (m.)’; but *qaṭálū without tonic lengthening. Note that vowels in closed

syllables, including those that were closed by the first apocope, did not undergo tonic lengthening. This is why tonic lengthening does not operate in most verbal forms.

The orthographical conventions of the Hebrew Bible reflect a period between (3.3) and (3.4): mimation has been lost, but tonically lengthened vowels are generally spelled defectively (e.g. גָּבֹהַ 'high (m.sg.)'), unlike historically long vowels, which may be spelled plene (e.g. קוֹל < *qāl- 'voice').

After tonic lengthening, a second round of apocope deleted the new instances of short word-final vowels:

(3.5) New cases of unstressed, word-final *a and *e are deleted.

E.g. *dabā́re > *dabā́r 'word'.

3.1.4 Pretonic lengthening

Many vowels in open syllables preceding the stress were also lengthened. The three short vowels behave differently.

(3.6) *a > *ā in open syllables directly preceding the stress.

*e and *o had previously been reduced or deleted in pretonic syllables, except when preceding *a (but were later analogically restored before morpheme boundaries). Thus, words like *zerṓʿ- > *zərṓʿ 'arm' did not undergo pretonic lengthening. Where *e and *o were present, they behaved as follows:

(3.7) *e > *ē in open syllables directly preceding the stress, except when directly preceded by a heavy syllable.

(3.8) *oC > *oCC in open syllables directly preceding the stress, except when directly preceded by a heavy syllable.

The behaviour of the different vowels can be seen in words like *dabā́r > *dābā́r 'word'; *ʿōlamī́m > *ʿōlāmī́m 'eternities'; *śeʿā́r > *śēʿā́r 'hair'; but *kōhenī́m 'priests' without pretonic lengthening; *ʿamoqī́m > *ʿamoqqī́m 'deep (m.pl.)'; but *yaqṭolū́n without pretonic lengthening.

3.1.5 Diphthong contraction

(3.9) Except in a few very specific environments, both stressed and unstressed *aw > *ō, except when followed by *w.

The resulting cases of spellings like יום for *yṓm- < *yáwm- led to the use of *wåw* as a mater lectionis for instances of *ō resulting from Proto-Northwest-Semitic *ā, as in the feminine plural ending, *-ṓt-. As was implied above, this suggests that the contraction of *aw preceded tonic lengthening.

(3.10) *ay > *ē, except when followed by *y or in word-final syllables.

E.g. *ʿāláynū > *ʿālḗnū 'on us'; *zaytīm > *zētīm 'olive trees'; but contrast the singular *záyt without contraction. The conditioning shows that the contraction of *ay postdates the second apocope (3.5).

3.2 Morphosyntactic developments

3.2.1 Pronouns, nouns and adjectives

The second apocope (3.5) caused the merger of the different case forms in the singular of most words. This led to a collapse of the case system. Where different distinct case forms should have been preserved, we see that it is always the form of the genitive that is generalized. Thus, in the dual and plural, the oblique endings *-áym and *-ím replace the original nominative endings, *-ṓm and *-ṹm. Monosyllabic words or those ending in original triphthongs, which probably lost their mimation in the singular through analogy, also generalize the original genitive form, e.g. *pḗ 'mouth', *śādḗ 'field', replacing the original nominatives, where different, and the original accusatives like *pṓ and *śādā́. Similarly, the original genitive form of the demonstrative pronoun, *zḗ, becomes dominant, although the original nominative *zṹ and accusative *zṓ were marginally retained.

The loss of the case system may have contributed to the rise of the definite article, *haC-, and the nota objecti, *ʾōt-/*ʾet-.

In the feminine suffix *-ā́t < *-at-, word-final *t was lost, yielding the absolute ending *-ā. *t was preserved in the construct ending *-at because it was not prosodically in word-final position.

3.2.2 Verbs

In several very specific circumstances, the stress shifted from the penultimate to the ultimate syllable. Among other things, this resulted in the merger of many forms of the jussive and the imperfect, eventually leading to the spread of original jussive forms like *yaqṭólū to the imperfect.

Due to a minor sound change, some prefix vowels were raised: in the fientive G-stem of the strong verb, *ya- etc. changed to *ye- etc., while in the perfect and participle of the strong N-stem, *na- changed to *ne-.

Through analogy with II-weak C-stem forms like *hēqḯm 'he erected' and *yāqḯm 'he will erect', the strong C-stem third person perfect changed from *heqṭél to *heqṭḯl, and the imperfect forms like *yaqṭél changed to forms like *yaqṭḯl. Strong C-stem jussive forms like *yaqṭél (< *yáqṭel) were preserved.

In Classical (i.e. post-Archaic) Biblical Hebrew, we see some changes in the use of the different tenses. The jussive loses its original past tense value, which is only preserved in the new *consecutive imperfect* *way-yeqṭól, of unclear origin but seemingly formed by prefixing the conjunction *wa- 'and' to the jussive. While the imperfect is still used for habitual action, durative aspect is expressed by a non-verbal clause containing a participle, e.g. *ʾánī šōlḗḥ 'I am sending'.

4. Proto-Jewish Hebrew

4.1 Phonological developments

4.1.1 Loss of the lateral fricative(s)

(4.1) *ś, still spelled with שׂ, merges with *s (< *^{t}s), resulting in Biblical Hebrew *śin*. If *ṣ́ was still preserved up to this point, it merges with *ṣ.

The occasional interchange between *śin* and *såmɛḵ* in post-exilic Hebrew attests to this merger.

4.1.2 Pausal lengthening

(4.2) In utterance-final words, stressed short vowels are lengthened.

4.1.3 Short stress shift and reduction

(4.3) The stress shifts from a short vowel in an open syllable to a directly following vowel.

This stress shift affects those vowels in open syllables that did not undergo tonic lengthening because of the following long vowel, like *qāṭálū > *qāṭalṹ, as well as some words with newly-developed word-final vowels, like *ṣáby > *ṣábī > *ṣabḭ́ 'gazelle'. Note that this stress shift is blocked by pausal lengthening (4.2), as in the pausal form *qāṭálū > *qāṭ́álū.
After the short stress shift, unstressed short vowels in open syllables were reduced to schwa.

(4.4) Unstressed *V̆ > *ə in open syllables.[9]

After gutturals, short vowels were usually retained; these show up as the *ḥåṭep̄* vowels in Biblical Hebrew. The realization of the *ḥåṭep̄* vowel does not always correspond to its original quality.

[9] *o in word-initial syllables was preserved, e.g. in *qodāšḭ́m 'holies', *ṣorḭ́ 'mastic'.

4.2 Morphosyntactic developments

The Biblical texts composed in the post-exilic period show varying levels of influence from the colloquial register of Hebrew, many features of which are attested in Rabbinic Hebrew. Most importantly, the consecutive imperfect becomes obsolete, while the perfect expands its meaning to express any past event; the imperfect is restricted to modal uses, while the participle evolves into a present tense form; and the Classical Biblical Hebrew relative particle *ʾašer is replaced by *šeC-.

5. Masoretic Hebrew

5.1 Phonological developments

5.1.1 Changes in vowel quality

Unstressed *e and *o developed into either high or mid-low vowels. *e was normally raised to *i in pretonic syllables, except when adjacent to a guttural (and even then sometimes, especially before geminates); in other positions, it was lowered to *ɛ. *o was raised to *u before most geminates and lowered to *ɔ elsewhere. Examples: *yeqṭól > *yiqṭól; *wayyḗred > *wayyḗrɛd 'and he descended'; *kollṓ > *kullṓ 'all of it (m.)', *godlṓ > *gɔdlṓ 'his greatness'.

In the Babylonian and Tiberian reading traditions, *ā was backed to *å̄.

5.1.2 Philippi's Law

Already at the Proto-Hebrew stage, stressed *e was slightly lowered to *ɛ when occurring before two different consonants.[10] This allophone acquired a marginal phonemic status due to the subsequent assimilation of *n (3.1), e.g. in *bént > *bént > *bétt 'daughter'. In the (pre-)Masoretic period, this and other cases of (secondarily) stressed *é in closed syllables shifted to *á. The combined effect of these sound changes is known as Philippi's Law.

(5.1) *éC$_1$C$_2$ > *éC$_1$C$_2$ in medial and word-final syllables.

(5.2) *éC$ > *áC$

The effects of Philippi's Law are conspicuous in the G-stem stative verb, e.g. *zaqéntī > *zaqéntī > *zāqántī 'I am old'[11] (cf. the 3m.sg. *zāqén without Philippi's Law) and in many *qiṭl- nouns, e.g. *ṣédq > *ṣédq > *ṣádq 'righteousness' (cf. *ṣidqṓ 'his righteousness).

5.1.3 Degemination and segolization

Word-final geminates were simplified to single consonants. Geminated gutturals and *r were simplified in all positions with compensatory lengthening of the preceding vowel; the voiceless fricatives *ḫ, *ḥ, and *h seem to have been preserved as geminates for longer than the voiced consonants and *ʾ. Where a cluster of two different consonants occurred in word-final position, an epenthetic vowel was inserted: *a if the first

[10] Except in the first syllable of polysyllabic words, e.g. *qédmā 'eastwards', *léknā 'go (f.pl.)'.
[11] *n was analogically restored in this word.

consonant was a guttural, *i after *ɣ, *ɛ otherwise. The vowel in the preceding syllable underwent compensatory lengthening.

(5.3) Word-finally, *C_1C_1 > *C_1.

(5.4) *$\breve{V}G_1G_1$ > *$\bar{V}G_1$

(5.5) Word-finally, *$\breve{V}G_1C_2$ > *$\bar{V}G_1aC_2$; *$\breve{V}yC$ > *$\bar{V}yiC$; other cases of *$\breve{V}C_1C_2$ > *$\bar{V}C_1\varepsilon C_2$.

*ā in a newly opened syllable assimilated to a following *ɛ. This resulted in three main classes of segolates: *qáṭl > *qɛ́ṭɛl, *qéṭl > *qɛ́ṭɛl,[12] and *qóṭl > *qɔ́ṭɛl.

5.1.4 Loss of velar fricatives and spirantization

The velar fricatives *ḫ and *ġ merged with *ḥ and *ʿ, respectively. As the consonantal script had not distinguished between velar and pharyngeal fricatives, this did not result in new graphemes, as did happen in the case of *śin*.

(5.6) *ḫ > *ḥ, *ġ > *ʿ

Later, new fricatives developed out of the unemphatic plosives in a change known as *begadkephat spirantization*.

(5.7) Postvocalic, non-geminated *b > *b̲, *g > *ḡ, *d > *d̲, *k > *k̲, *p > *p̄, *t > *t̲.

5.1.5 Attenuation and partial loss of contrastive length

The Law of Attenuation is the supposed sound law that changed unstressed *a to *i in unstressed syllables in Hebrew. In fact, there was no single Law of Attenuation, but a number of separate developments, operating throughout the history of Hebrew; we have already seen two such developments in some verbal prefixes (sections 2.2.3 and 3.2.2).

Another category of seeming examples of the Law of Attenuation result from the loss of schwa after open syllables; this caused some other cases of schwa to be in newly closed syllables, where they changed to *i or *a.

(5.8) Schwa is deleted when directly preceded by an open syllable.

[12] This class contains words which analogically restored or gained an *e after the operation of Philippi's Law (section 5.1.2).

(5.9) Schwa in a closed syllable shifts to *a when adjacent to a guttural or before *r, *l, or *n; elsewhere, it shifts to *i.

E.g. *mələ̰kē > *məlḵē > *malḵē ‘kings (construct)’; *də̱bərē > *də̱brē > *diḇrē ‘words (construct)’.

These changes had important consequences for the phonemic inventory of Biblical Hebrew, together with the following two:

(5.10) Schwa is inserted between two word-initial consonants.

(5.11) All stressed short vowels are lengthened.

This resulted in the phonology attested in Masoretic Biblical Hebrew, with no phonemic schwa, /b̲ ḡ d̲ k̲ p̄ t̲/ as phonemic fricatives, and a severely limited vowel length contrast.

A uniquely Tiberian sound change that is usually grouped under the Law of Attenuation is the dissimilation of *a to *i in the first syllable of *maqṭal- nouns and phonetically similar forms. This did not take place before geminates or nasals or adjacent to gutturals.

5.2 Morphosyntactic developments

*5.2.1 Spread of *-ā*

Two different forms of the 2m.sg. independent personal pronoun occurred in Proto-Northwest-Semitic, *ʾanta and *ʾantah. The reflex of the former was almost completely lost in Hebrew, with *ʾantah > *ʾáttā > אַתָּה becoming the normal form. In an ancestor of the Tiberian reading tradition, the long final vowel of this pronoun spread to other 2m.sg. forms through analogy, resulting in forms like קָטַלְתָּ instead of *qāṭálta and the pronominal suffix -ָךָ instead of *-ak; the latter forms are attested in other reading traditions. The defective spelling of these forms still shows that they originally ended in a historically short vowel that was deleted by the first apocope. A similar contamination has affected the f.pl. imperfect ending -נָה instead of inherited *-na > *-n; the longer ending presumably took its long vowel from the 3f.pl. independent pronoun, הֵנָּה.

Texts

1. Amorite

Andrew George & Manfred Krebernik, 'Two Remarkable Vocabularies: Amorite-Akkadian Bilinguals!', *Revue d'assyriologie et d'archéologie orientale* 116 (2022), 113–166

2.12 *ta-aḫ-ni-šum ma-a ˹a˺-mu-ru-ul-la-ka*
*taʾnīθum ma yamuruⁿlaka
'What did the woman say to you?'

2.14 *ta-aḫ-ni-šum el-ḫa-ku-un-na-ni-la-a-ka*
*taʾnīθum yilʾakunnanī ilayka
'The woman sent me to you'

2.16 *ra-ḫa-a-a a-li-˹ku el˺-kum la ta-*[*aḫ-ni-ši*]*-˹ya˺*
*raʿayya aliku yilkum la taʾnīθīya
'My friends, I really must go to my wife'

2.22 *bi-ik-ra-ti-ia za-ba-a-ḫa a-na* DIĜIR*-ia la-am-˹ti˺-in*
*bikrātīya ðabāḫaⁿ la ilīya laⁿtiⁿ
2.23 *ì-lí ni-iḫ-ma-tam li-ir-ši-a-ni-ma*
*ilī niʿmataⁿ lirθiyannī-ma
2.24 *a-li-ku-na wa pa-aḫ-ma-*{x}*-a*
*alikunna wa-paʿmay
2.25 *ma-li-kum am-si-qu*
*malikiⁿ aⁿsiqu
'Let me give my firstfruits to my god as an offering,
let my god grant me favour, and
I will go and kiss the
king's feet'

2. Poenulus Maurice Sznycer, *Les passage puniques en transcription latine dans le « Poenulus » de Plaute* (Paris, 1967), 108–109

TEXTE I (vers 930-939)

Texte latin amendé et corrigé

930 YTH ALONIM UALONUTH SI CORATHI SY MACOM SYTH
931 CHY MLACHTHI IN YTHMUM YSTHYALM YCHI IBARCU MYSEHI
932 LI PHO CANETH YTH BYNUTHI IAD AEDYN BYN UI
933 BYMAROB SYLLOHOM ALONIM UYBYMYSYRTHOHO[M]
934 BYTH LYMMOTH YNNOCHO THUULECH ANTIDAMAS CHON
935 YS SI DOBRIM CHY FEL YTH CHIL YS CHON CHEN LIFUL
936 YTH BINIM YS DYBURTH INNOCHO TNU AGORASTOCLES
937 YTH EMANETHI HY CHIRS AELICHOT SITH NASO[T]
938 BYNNY ID LI CHI ILY GUBULIM LASIBITTHIM
939 BODI ALY THERA YNNYNNU YSLYM M⟨I⟩N CHO TH IUSIM

Transcription du texte punique

930 'T 'LNM W'LNT ŠQR'TY ŠMQM ST
931 KY ML'KTY HN 'TMM 'ŠT'LM WKY YBRK' MS'Y
933 BM'RB ŠLHM 'LNM WBMŠRTM
934 B'T LYMT HNKH THLK 'NTYDMS KN
935 'Š ŠDBRYM KY P'L 'T KL 'Š KN KN LP'L
936 'T BNM 'Š DBRT HNKH TN' 'GRSTQLS
937 'T 'MNTY H' HRŠ HHLKT ST NŠ'T
938 BN' YD LY KY 'L' GBLM LŠBTM
939 B'DY 'LY TR'H HNNY 'Š'LM MN K' T YṢ'YM

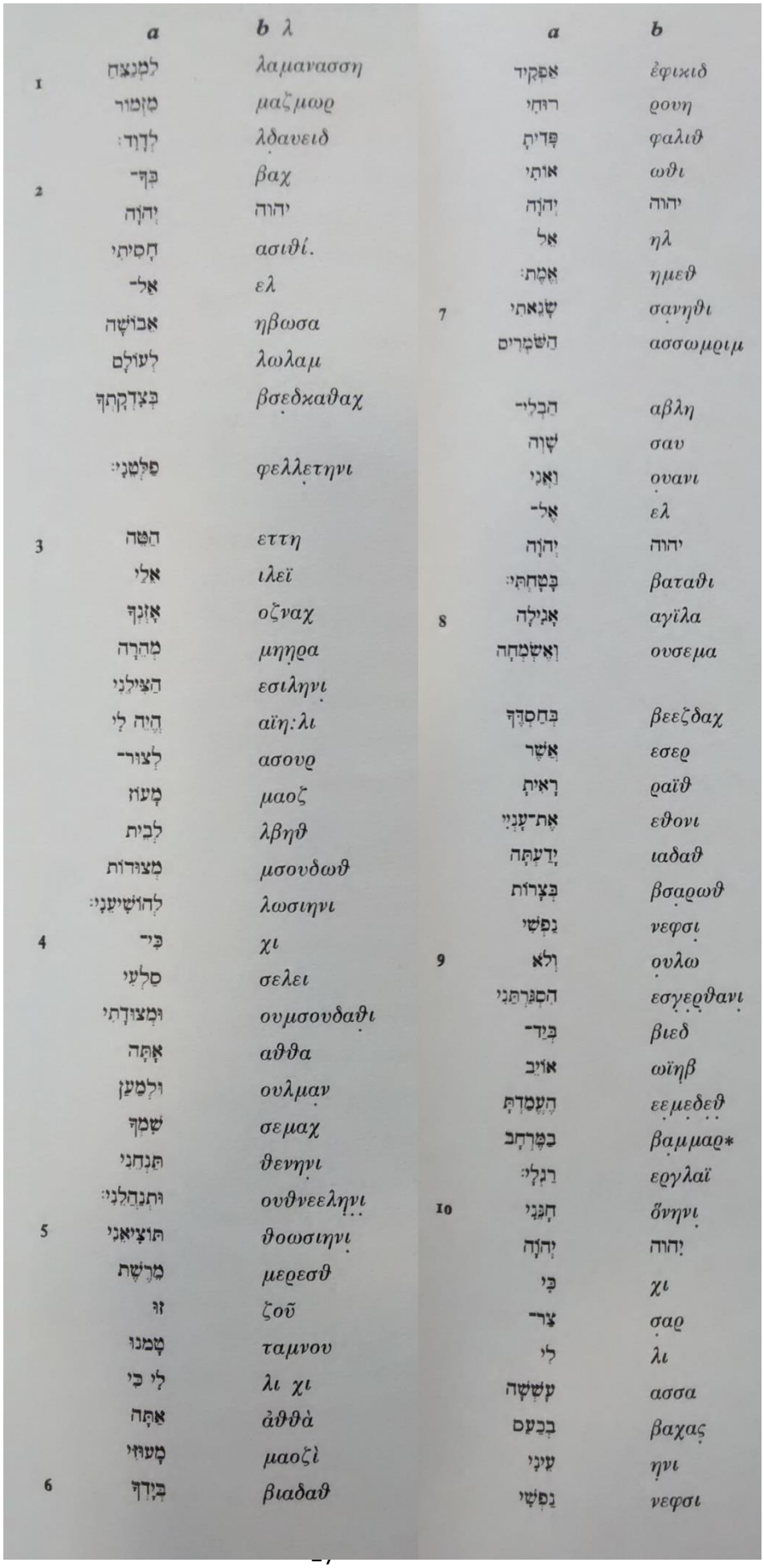
Traduction

(930) Les dieux et les déesses que j'invoque, qui sont (en) ce lieu-ci : (931) que je mène ici mon entreprise à bonne fin, je le leur demande et qu'ils bénissent mon voyage. (932) Puissé-je reprendre ici mes filles, en même temps encore mon neveu, (933) grâce à la protection des dieux et grâce à leur justice ! (934) Au temps jadis, voici que lui, Antidamas, fut ici (mon) hôte ; (935) un homme dont on (m')a dit qu'il a fait tout ce qu'il devait faire ainsi. (936) En ce qui concerne son fils, dont j'ai parlé, on (m')assure que lui, Agorastoclès, est ici. (937) Comme preuve, c'est cette tessère d'hospitalité que j'ai apportée (avec moi). (938) On m'a indiqué qu'il habite dans ces parages. (939) Pendant que moi je suis en observation, voici que j'interrogerai ceux qui sortent d'ici.

Traduction (suivie)

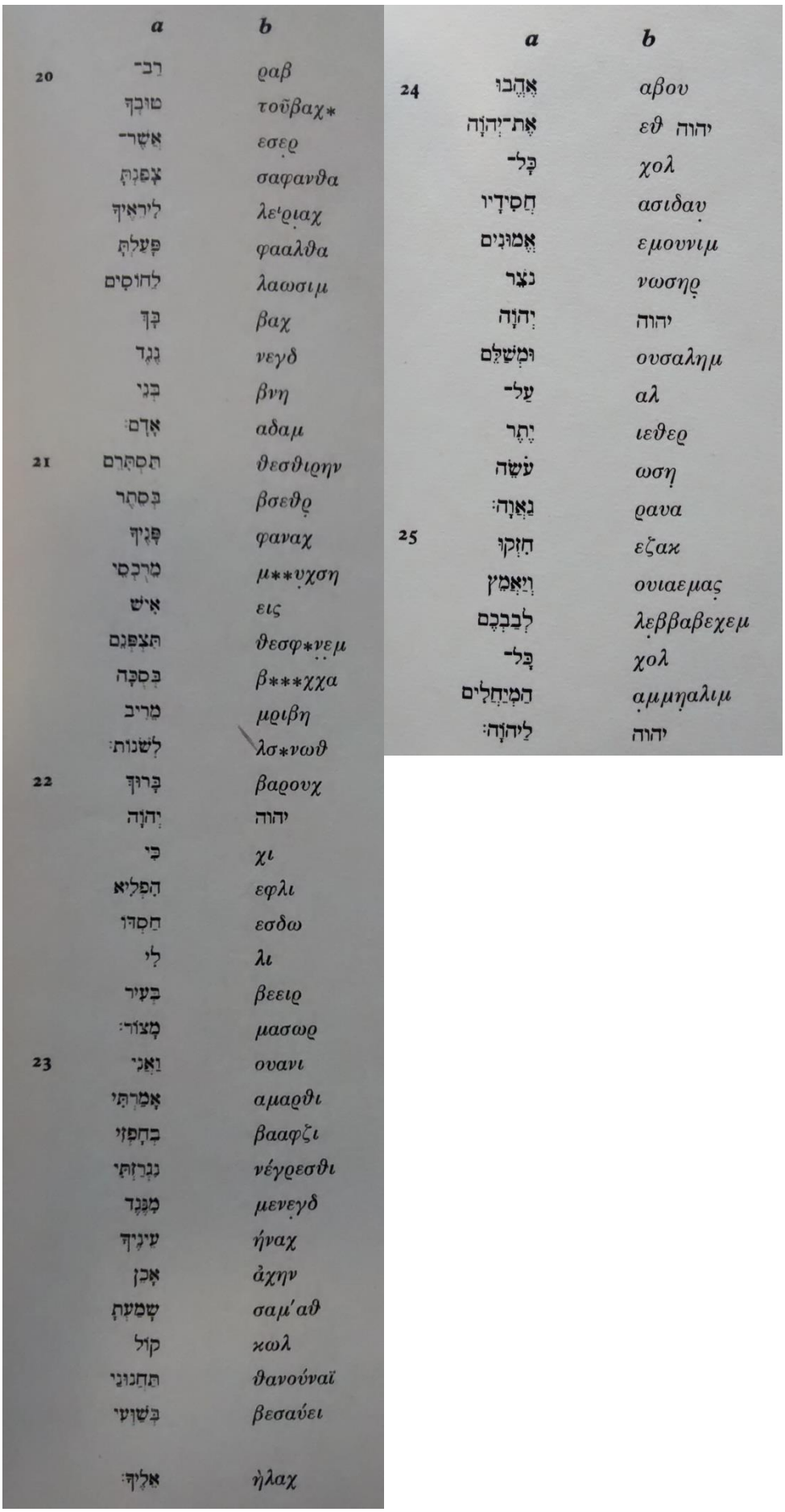
J'invoque les dieux et les déesses de cet endroit-ci : je leur demande de mener à bonne fin mon entreprise ici et de bénir mon voyage. Puissé-je, grâce à la protection des dieux et grâce à leur justice, reprendre ici mes filles et en même temps mon neveu ! Jadis Antidamas fut ici mon hôte ; on m'a dit qu'il a accompli son destin. En ce qui concerne son fils, dont j'ai parlé, on m'assure que Agorastoclès se trouve ici ; j'ai apporté avec moi, comme preuve, cette tessère d'hospitalité. On m'a indiqué qu'il (Agorastoclès) habite dans les environs ; je monterai donc la garde et m'informerai auprès de ces gens qui sortent d'ici.

3. Hexapla J. Mercati (Vatican City, 1958), *Psalterii hexapli reliquiae*, volume 1a



	a	b λ
1	לַמְנַצֵּחַ	λαμανασση
	מִזְמוֹר	μαζμωρ
	לְדָוִד׃	λδαυειδ
2	בְּךְ־	βαχ
	יְהוָה	יהוה
	חָסִיתִי	ασιθί.
	אַל־	ελ
	אֵבוֹשָׁה	ηβωσα
	לְעוֹלָם	λωλαμ
	בְּצִדְקָתְךָ	βσεδκαθαχ
	פַּלְּטֵנִי׃	φελλετηνι
3	הַטֵּה	εττη
	אֵלַי	ιλεϊ
	אָזְנְךָ	οζναχ
	מְהֵרָה	μηηρα
	הַצִּילֵנִי	εσιληνι
	הֱיֵה לִי	αϊη:λι
	לְצוּר־	ασουρ
	מָעוֹז	μαοζ
	לְבֵית	λβηθ
	מְצוּדוֹת	μσουδωθ
	לְהוֹשִׁיעֵנִי׃	λωσιηνι
4	כִּי־	χι
	סַלְעִי	σελει
	וּמְצוּדָתִי	ουμσουδαθι
	אָתָּה	αθθα
	וּלְמַעַן	ουλμαν
	שִׁמְךָ	σεμαχ
	תַּנְחֵנִי	θενηνι
	וּתְנַהֲלֵנִי׃	ουθνεεληνι
5	תּוֹצִיאֵנִי	θοωσιηνι
	מֵרֶשֶׁת	μερεσθ
	זוּ	ζοῦ
	טָמְנוּ	ταμνου
	לִי כִּי	λι χι
	אַתָּה	ἀθθὰ
	מָעוּזִּי	μαοζὶ
6	בְּיָדְךָ	βιαδαθ

	a	b
	אַפְקִיד	ἐφικιδ
	רוּחִי	ρουη
	פָּדִיתָ	φαλιθ
	אוֹתִי	ωθι
	יְהוָה	יהוה
	אֵל	ηλ
	אֱמֶת׃	ημεθ
7	שָׂנֵאתִי	σανηθι
	הַשֹּׁמְרִים	ασσωμριμ
	הַבְלֵי־	αβλη
	שָׁוְא	σαυ
	וַאֲנִי	ουανι
	אֶל־	ελ
	יְהוָה	יהוה
	בָּטָחְתִּי׃	βαταθι
8	אָגִילָה	αγϊλα
	וְאֶשְׂמְחָה	ουσεμα
	בְּחַסְדֶּךָ	βεεζδαχ
	אֲשֶׁר	εσερ
	רָאִיתָ	ραϊθ
	אֶת־עָנְיִי	εθονι
	יָדַעְתָּה	ιαδαθ
	בְּצָרוֹת	βσαρωθ
	נַפְשִׁי	νεφσι
9	וְלֹא	ουλω
	הִסְגַּרְתָּנִי	εσγερθανι
	בְּיַד־	βιεδ
	אוֹיֵב	ωϊηβ
	הֶעֱמַדְתָּ	εεμεδεθ
	בַּמֶּרְחָב	βαμμαρ*
	רַגְלָי׃	εργλαϊ
10	חָנֵּנִי	ὅνηνι
	יְהוָה	יהוה
	כִּי	χι
	צַר־	σαρ
	לִי	λι
	עָשְׁשָׁה	ασσα
	בְכַעַס	βαχας
	עֵינִי	ηνι
	נַפְשִׁי	νεφσι



	a	*b*
20	רַב־	*ραβ*
	טוּבְךָ	*τοῦβαχ**
	אֲשֶׁר־	*εσερ*
	צָפַנְתָּ	*σαφανθα*
	לִירֵאֶיךָ	*λε'ριαχ*
	פָּעַלְתָּ	*φααλθα*
	לַחוֹסִים	*λαωσιμ*
	בָּךְ	*βαχ*
	נֶגֶד	*νεγδ*
	בְּנֵי	*βνη*
	אָדָם׃	*αδαμ*
21	תְּסִתִּרֵם	*θεσθιρην*
	בְּסֵתֶר	*βσεθρ*
	פָּנֶיךָ	*φαναχ*
	מֵרְכְסֵי	*μ**υχση*
	אִישׁ	*εις*
	תְּצַפְּנֵם	*θεσφ*νεμ*
	בְּסֻכָּה	*β***χχα*
	מֵרִיב	*μριβη*
	לְשׁוֹנוֹת׃	*λσ*νωθ*
22	בָּרוּךְ	*βαρουχ*
	יְהוָה	*יהוה*
	כִּי	*χι*
	הִפְלִיא	*εφλι*
	חַסְדּוֹ	*εσδω*
	לִי	*λι*
	בְּעִיר	*βεειρ*
	מָצוֹר׃	*μασωρ*
23	וַאֲנִי	*ουανι*
	אָמַרְתִּי	*αμαρθι*
	בְחָפְזִי	*βααφζι*
	נִגְרַזְתִּי	*νέγρεσθι*
	מִנֶּגֶד	*μενεγδ*
	עֵינֶיךָ	*ήναχ*
	אָכֵן	*ἀχην*
	שָׁמַעְתָּ	*σαμ'αθ*
	קוֹל	*κωλ*
	תַּחֲנוּנָי	*θανούναϊ*
	בְּשַׁוְּעִי	*βεσαύει*
	אֵלֶיךָ׃	*ήλαχ*

	a	*b*
24	אֲהֵבוּ	*αβου*
	אֶת־יְהוָה	*εθ יהוה*
	כָּל־	*χολ*
	חֲסִידָיו	*ασιδαυ*
	אֱמוּנִים	*εμουνιμ*
	נֹצֵר	*νωσηρ*
	יְהוָה	*יהוה*
	וּמְשַׁלֵּם	*ουσαλημ*
	עַל־	*αλ*
	יֶתֶר	*ιεθερ*
	עֹשֵׂה	*ωση*
	גַּאֲוָה׃	*ραυα*
25	חִזְקוּ	*εζακ*
	וְיַאֲמֵץ	*ουιαεμας*
	לְבַבְכֶם	*λεββαβεχεμ*
	כָּל־	*χολ*
	הַמְיַחֲלִים	*αμμηαλιμ*
	לַיהוָה׃	*יהוה*

4.1 Samaritan Pentateuch Zeev Ben-Ḥayyim (Jerusalem 1977), עברית וארמית נוסח שומרון, vol. 4

שמות

å'ēluwwəm man ammå:ni wyittīṣåbu aftēttət år. [18] wår sīni ʿāšən kallu miffåni ēšår yåråd šēmå ʿālo bēš wyāl ʿašnu kāšən akkåbåšån wyērråd kal år mē'od. [19] wyå'i qol aššūfår ålåk wåzåq mē'od mūši yēdabbər wå'ēluwwəm yā:ninnu baqqol. [20] wyåråd šēmå al år sīni al rē'oš år wyiqra šēmå al mūši al rē'oš år wyāl mūši. * [21] wyå'ūmər šēmå al mūši råd å'əd bām fan yērråsu al šēmå alrå'ot wnåfål mimminnu råb. [22] wgam akkå'ēnəm annēgīšəm al šēmå yitqåddåšu fan yifråṣ bimma šēmå. [23] wyå'ūmər mūši al šēmå lå yūkål ʿām lā:lot al år sīni kī åttå å'idtå bånu līmor agbəl it år wqaddištu. [24] wyå'ūmər īlo šēmå lik råd wāllītå åttå wårron immåk wakkå'ēnəm wām al yērråsu lā:lot al šēmå fan yifråṣ bimma. [25] wyåråd mūši man år al ʿām wyå'ūmər īlīyyimma. *

20

[1] wyēdabbər ēluwwəm it kal addēbårəm å'illa līmor. [2] ånåki šēmå ēluwwåk ēšår ūṣåttək miyyårəṣ miṣrəm mibbət ʿåbådəm. [3] lå yēyyi låk ēluwwəm å'ērəm ʿal fåni. [4] lå tēššī låk afsəl wkal tēmūna ēšår baššåməm mimmiyyal wēšår bårəṣ mit'tēt wēšår bamməm mit'tēt lårəṣ. [5] lå tištåbbi lēmma wlå tåbbådimma kī ånåki šēmå ēluwwåk il qånå fūqəd ūn åbot ʿal bånəm ʿal šēlīšå'əm wal rēbiyyå'əm alšannā'i. [6] wāši ēsəd lålåfəm lå'ēbi walšåmēri mēṣåbūti. [7] lå tišša it šam šēmå ēluwwåk alšu kī lå yēnaqqi šēmå it ēšår yišša it šēmu alšu. * [8] šēmor it yom aššåbbåt alqådēšē'u. [9] šiššåt yåməm tēbbåd waššītå kal målåktåk. [10] wyom aššē'bī šåbbåt alšēmå ēluwwåk lå tēššī bū kal målåka åttå wbēnåk wbittåk ʿåbdåk wåmåtåk bīmtåk wgīråk ēšår afšārək. [11] kī šiššåt yåməm ʿāša šēmå it aššåməm wit å:rəṣ it ayyåm wit kal ēšår bimma wyanna bayyom aššē'bī ʿal kan barrək šēmå it yom aššåbbåt wyēqaddēšē'u. * [12] kēbåd it åbək wit immåk al'mān yårrīkon yåmək ʿal å:dåmå ēšår šēmå ēluwwåk nåtån låk. [13] lå tirṣå lå tēnā'əf lå tignåb lå tānna ab'rēk id ašqår. [14] lå tēmmåd bit rēk wlå tēmmåd iššåt rēk šådē'u ʿabdu wåmåtu šūru wēmūru wkal ēšår al'rēk. * [14^1] wēyya kī yībiyyåk šēmå ēluwwåk al årəṣ akkånānni ēšår åttå bā šamma alrišta wīqimtå låk åbånəm gådallot wšådåtå ūtimma afšiyyåd wkåtåbtå ʿal åbånəm it kal dēbåri attūra azzē'ot. [14^2] wēyya båbbårkimma it ayyårdån tīqīmu it å:bånəm å'illa ēšår ånåki amṣåbi itkimma ayyom bårgårīzəm. [14^3] wbånītå šamma mazba alšēmå ēluwwåk mazba åbånəm lå tīnəf ʿālīyyimma barzəl åbånəm šalmot tibni it mazba šēmå ēluwwåk. [14^4] wāllītå ʿālo ʿālot alšēmå ēluwwåk wzēbāttå šēlammən wåkåltå šamma wšåmåttå alfåni šēmå ēluwwåk. [14^5] år å'ū bēbår ayyårdån å'ūri dērək må'bū aššīməš bårəṣ akkånānni ayyēšəb båråbå mol aggålgål ēṣəl ålon mūra mol aškəm. [15] wkal ʿām šāma it aqqūlot wit qol aššūfår wrå'əm it allabbīdəm wit år ʿāšən wyērē'u kal ʿām wyannā'u wyåmmådu mir'råq. [15^1] wyå'ūmēru al mūši an arrånu šēmå ēluwwīnu it kåbūdu wit gådlu wit qūlu šāmānnu mittok å'əš. [15^2] ayyom azze

4.2 SP and MT consonantal text Abraham Ṭal and Moshe

Florentin (Tel Aviv 2010), חמישה חומשי תורה נוסח שומרון ונוסח המסורה

ד וְכָל־
הָעָם רֹאִים אֶת־הַקּוֹלֹת וְאֶת־הַלַּפִּידִם וְאֵת קוֹל הַשֹּׁפָר וְאֶת־הָהָר
עָשֵׁן וַיַּרְא ◄ ◄ הָעָם וַיָּנֻעוּ וַיַּעַמְדוּ מֵרָחֹק: ה וַיֹּאמְרוּ אֶל־מֹשֶׁה ◄

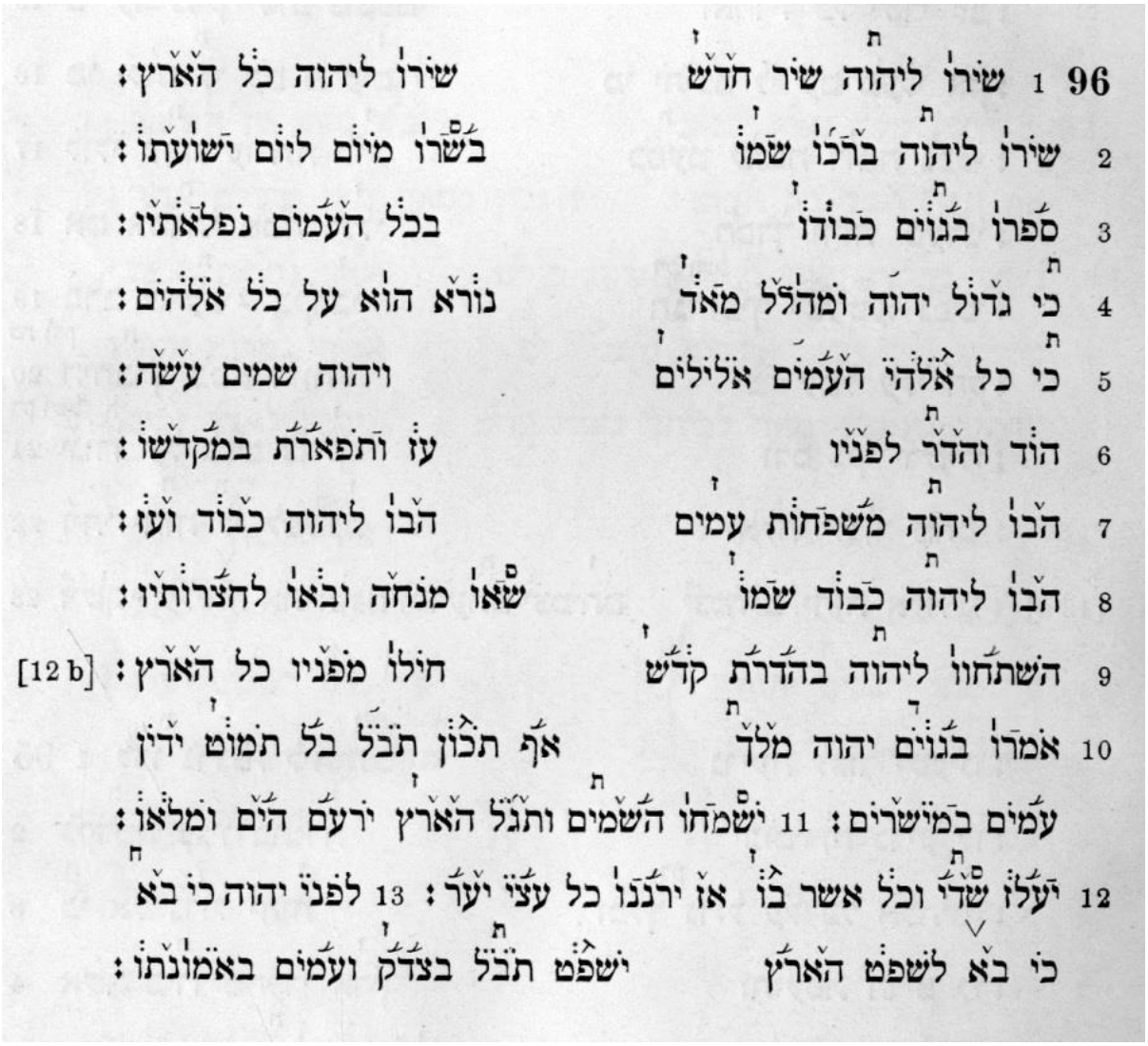
◄ דַּבֵּר־אַתָּה עִמָּנוּ
◄ ◄ וְנִשְׁמָעָה ◄ ◄ וְאַל־יְדַבֵּר עִמָּנוּ
אֱלֹהִים פֶּן־נָמוּת: ו וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה אֶל־הָעָם אַל־תִּירָאוּ כִּי לְבַעֲבוּר נַסּוֹת
אֶתְכֶם בָּא הָאֱלֹהִים וּבַעֲבוּר תִּהְיֶה יִרְאָתוֹ עַל־פְּנֵיכֶם לְבִלְתִּי תֶחֱטָאוּ:
ז וַיַּעֲמֹד הָעָם מֵרָחֹק וּמֹשֶׁה נִגַּשׁ אֶל־הָעֲרָפֶל אֲשֶׁר־שָׁם הָאֱלֹהִים
◄

ס :◄
ח וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוָה אֶל־מֹשֶׁה ◄ כֹּה תֹאמַר אֶל־בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אַתֶּם רְאִיתֶם
כִּי מִן־הַשָּׁמַיִם דִּבַּרְתִּי עִמָּכֶם: ט לֹא תַעֲשׂוּן אִתִּי אֱלֹהֵי כֶסֶף וֵאלֹהֵי זָהָב
לֹא תַעֲשׂוּ לָכֶם: י מִזְבַּח אֲדָמָה תַּעֲשֶׂה־לִּי וְזָבַחְתָּ עָלָיו אֶת־עֹלֹתֶיךָ וְאֶת־

והעלית עליו עלות ליהוה אלהיך [13ו] וזבחת שלמים ואכלת שם ושמחת
לפני יהוה אלהיך. ההר ההוא בעבר הירדן אחרי דרך מבוא השמש בארץ
הכנעני הישב בערבה מול הגלגל אצל אלון מורא מול שכם:<-- 14 **וכל
העם שמע את הקולות ואת** קול השופר וראים את הלפידים **ואת ההר
עשן** וירא כל **העם וינעו ויעמדו מרחק** 15 **ויאמרו אל משה** הן הראנו
יהוה אלהינו את כבודו ואת גדלו ואת קולו שמענו מתוך האש. היום הזה
ראינו כי ידבר אלהים את האדם וחי. ועתה למה נמות כי תאכלנו האש
הגדלה הזאת. אם יספים אנחנו לשמע את קול יהוה אלהינו עוד ומתנו. כי
מי כל בשר אשר שמע קול אלהים חיים מדבר מתוך האש כמונו ויחי.
קרב אתה ושמע את כל אשר יאמר יהוה אלהינו ואתה תדבר אלינו
את כל אשר ידבר יהוה אלהינו אליך ושמענו ועשינו. **ואל ידבר עמנו
האלהים פן נמות** 16 **ויאמר משה אל העם אל תיראו כי לבעבור נסות
אתכם בא האלהים** *בעבור **תהיה יראתו על פניכם לבלתי תחטאו**
17 **ויעמד העם מרחק ומשה נגש אל הערפל אשר שם האלהים**:<--
17א וידבר יהוה אל משה לאמר שמעתי את קול דברי העם הזה אשר
דברו אליך היטיבו כל אשר דברו 17ב מי יתן והיה לבבם זה להם ליראה
אתי ולשמר את מצותי כל הימים למען ייטב להם ולבניהם לעולם 17ג נביא
אקים להם מקרב אחיהם כמוך ונתתי דברי בפיו ודבר אליהם את כל
אשר אצונו 17ד והיה האיש אשר לא ישמע אל דבריו אשר ידבר בשמי
אנכי אדרש מעמו [17ה] אך הנביא אשר יזיד לדבר דבר בשמי את אשר
לא צויתיו לדבר ואשר ידבר בשם אלהים אחרים ומת הנביא ההוא 17ו וכי
תאמר בלבבך איך נודע את הדבר אשר לא דברו יהוה [17ז] אשר ידבר
הנביא בשם יהוה לא יהיה הדבר ולא יבוא הוא הדבר אשר לא דברו יהוה
בזידון דברו הנביא לא תגור ממנו 17ח לך אמר להם שובו לכם לאהליכם
[17ט] ואתה פה עמד עמדי ואדברה אליך את כל המצוה החקים והמשפטים
אשר תלמדם ועשו בארץ אשר אנכי נתן להם לרשתה:<--
18 וידבר **יהוה אל משה** לאמר דבר **אל בני ישראל אתם ראיתם
כי מן השמים דברתי עמכם** 19 **לא תעשו אתי אלהי כסף ואלהי זהב
לא תעשו לכם** 20 **מזבח אדמה תעשה לי וזבחת עליו את עלתיך ואת**

B. D. Suchard, Leiden University

5. Babylonian reading tradition Paul Kahle (Leipzig 1902), *Der Masoretische Text des Alten Testaments: nach der Überlieferung der babylonischen Juden*



שִׁירוּ לַיהוָה שִׁיר חָדָשׁ 1 **96**
שִׁירוּ לַיהוָה כָּל הָאָרֶץ׃
שִׁירוּ לַיהוָה בָּרְכוּ שְׁמוֹ 2
בַּשְּׂרוּ מִיּוֹם לְיוֹם יְשׁוּעָתוֹ׃
סַפְּרוּ בַגּוֹיִם כְּבוֹדוֹ 3
בְּכָל הָעַמִּים נִפְלְאוֹתָיו׃
כִּי גָדוֹל יְהוָה וּמְהֻלָּל מְאֹד 4
נוֹרָא הוּא עַל כָּל אֱלֹהִים׃
כִּי כָל אֱלֹהֵי הָעַמִּים אֱלִילִים 5
וַיהוָה שָׁמַיִם עָשָׂה׃
הוֹד וְהָדָר לְפָנָיו 6
עֹז וְתִפְאֶרֶת בְּמִקְדָּשׁוֹ׃
הָבוּ לַיהוָה מִשְׁפְּחוֹת עַמִּים 7
הָבוּ לַיהוָה כָּבוֹד וָעֹז׃
הָבוּ לַיהוָה כְּבוֹד שְׁמוֹ 8
שְׂאוּ מִנְחָה וּבֹאוּ לְחַצְרוֹתָיו׃
הִשְׁתַּחֲווּ לַיהוָה בְּהַדְרַת קֹדֶשׁ 9
חִילוּ מִפָּנָיו כָּל הָאָרֶץ׃ [12 b]
אִמְרוּ בַגּוֹיִם יְהוָה מָלָךְ 10
אַף תִּכּוֹן תֵּבֵל בַּל תִּמּוֹט יָדִין
עַמִּים בְּמֵישָׁרִים׃ 11 יִשְׂמְחוּ הַשָּׁמַיִם וְתָגֵל הָאָרֶץ יִרְעַם הַיָּם וּמְלֹאוֹ׃
יַעֲלֹז שָׂדַי וְכֹל אֲשֶׁר בּוֹ אָז יְרַנְּנוּ כָּל עֲצֵי יָעַר׃ 13 לִפְנֵי יְהוָה כִּי בָא 12
כִּי בָא לִשְׁפֹּט הָאָרֶץ
יִשְׁפֹּט תֵּבֵל בְּצֶדֶק וְעַמִּים בֶּאֱמוּנָתוֹ׃

בַ בُ בִ בֶ בָ בֹ בְ

/i/ /e/ /a/ /å/ /o/ /u/ /ə/

Exercises

1. The origin of the Biblical Hebrew stress system

Below, you see a number of Biblical Hebrew verbal forms. The pausal form is given, as this usually preserves the original position of the stress.

A) Give the Proto-Northwest-Semitic reconstruction of every form (see table 1.5).

B) Looking at the PNWS forms and the position of the stress in Biblical Hebrew (indicated by *ʾaṯnåḥ*, ◌֢), what rule determines which syllable is stressed?

1. קָטַל
2. קָטָלָה
3. קָטָלְתָּ
4. קָטַלְתִּ
5. יִקְטֹל
6. יִקְטְלוּ
7. יִקְטֹלְנָה
8. תִּקְטֹלְנָה

2. Triphthong contraction

A) Based on chapter 1, reconstruct strong PNWS verbal forms of the roots given in column 1 below. Note: *bny has an *i in the second syllable of the imperfect and jussive.

B) Give the Biblical Hebrew reflex of each form in column 2. The BH reflex of the PNWS root is given for ease of reference.

	1. *bny 'to build', fientive G-stem	2. בנה, fientive *qal*
3m.sg. perfect		
3m.pl. perfect		
3m.sg. imperfect		
3m.pl. jussive		
m.sg. passive participle		
	1. *qwm 'to stand up', fientive G-stem	2. קום, fientive *qal*
3m.sg. perfect		

3. From PNWS to Proto-Hebrew

Apply the sound changes we have discussed so far to the reconstructed quasi-Proto-Northwest-Semitic sentences below in order to arrive at their Proto-Hebrew reflexes. Words that are connected to a following word by a hyphen are proclitic and therefore unstressed. Due to sound change that has not yet been mentioned, *h is elided before a short, word-final vowel; in these cases, this results in *-īhu > *-īw and *-ahu > *-ō; also, stressed word-final *-ī > *-ē. For imaginary bonus points, translate the sentences as well.

*wayyaʾmur yawᵗsipum ʾila ʾabīhu:

*lā kawinam, ʾabīya, kī-**ḏī** han-bukurum

*śīm yamīnaka ʿala **raʾsahu**[13]

[13] The bolded reconstructions were chosen to yield the correct Hebrew form, but they are not the forms PNWS would actually use in this context. For even more imaginary bonus points, why are they wrong and what would the correct forms be?

4. Stress shift and vowel reduction

Below, you see several verbal and nominalized forms of the Proto-Northwest-Semitic root *kbd ‘to be heavy’. Apply the sound changes we have discussed so far to these forms, most notably:

- lowering of short vowels
- tonic and pretonic lengthening
- apocope
- stress shift from short vowels
- vowel reduction

1. *kabida ‘he is heavy’
2. *kabidat ‘she is heavy’
3. *kabidū ‘they are heavy’
4. *yikbadū ‘they (m.) will become heavy’[14]
5. *kabidum ‘heavy (m.sg.)’
6. *kabidātum ‘heavy (f.pl.)’
7. *yinkabidū ‘they (m.) will be honoured’
8. *nakbadaka ‘your (m.) honoured one (m.)’

[14] Originally ‘they (m.) became heavy’; the expansion of this jussive form to the imperfect is mentioned in section 3.2.2.